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Warm pastry, cold rain and empty pews

James Merriman pays a breathless visit to a misty Lake Bled in Slovenia

The road to Bled from Ljubljana winds through foothills and villages. Fields and mountains appear between gaps in the trees. When the lake finally comes into view, the afternoon sun catches the water and turns the surface silver. The island sits in the middle of the lake with its church tower rising above the trees. The postcard view is suddenly no longer a photograph.

Our dinner the first night is Carniolan sausage. The smoked pork is heavy with garlic and piled next to sharp mustard, mashed potato and sauerkraut. We drink cold Union beer. Dessert is *kremšnita*, Bled's famous cream cake. Two thin layers of crisp pastry hold a thick layer of vanilla custard and whipped cream. When the knife pierces the top, the whole slice collapses slightly onto the plate.

An early morning queue leads to a wooden boat named Julia. A group of 22 of us pile in. The oarsman stands upright at the back and hauls the oars through the water. A glass sits next to his feet, filled with an amber liquid that looks suspiciously like a breakfast pint.



The boat crosses the calm water in 25 minutes. The island slowly grows larger ahead of us. A total of 99 stone steps lead up towards the church; visitors stop halfway to catch their breath. Inside, the bell rope hangs ready. Thousands of hands have pulled it, and it is worn smooth. The sound of the bell rolls out across the lake, reaches the surrounding hills and disappears.

We buy a snack - *potica* - for the return journey. The thick walnut pastry is rolled into tight, heavy layers that manage to survive being eaten on a moving boat.

Back on the mainland, the route leads away from the busiest part of the shoreline. A small bakery used by locals appears and provides a warm cheese borek. This pastry is Slovenia's answer to a pasty on the move. We are on the track towards Ojstrica, which leaves the easy lakeside route and turns sharply upwards. Limestone rocks shift



A rain-soaked heart waits on Lake Bled

underfoot as the path narrows and the shade disappears. Humidity makes the climb harder than the height suggests.

At the 618-metre viewpoint, my shirt is damp with sweat. The trees open onto a view of Bled Island sitting perfectly in the centre of the lake below us. The Julian Alps stretch across the horizon, sharp and bright under the afternoon sun.

The descent is slower, as loose stones move beneath our feet. Down on the flat path beside the lake, the even ground feels so easy. We stop at Park Café for another slice of *kremšnita*: the recipe was invented here, they say. Almost every table has the same square of custard and pastry sitting on it. The terrace is packed. Heavy clouds roll in over the water, but the rain holds off.

Afterwards, the route towards St Martin's Church climbs away from the crowds and becomes quieter with every step. Swans stand close to the water and lavender grows beside the stone walls. The church sits above the lake, small and peaceful.

Inside, empty benches and soft light fall across the stone floor. A woman stands near the aisle. For a moment, I think it is my mum (who died suddenly 18 months ago). She has the same posture, her head tilted slightly to the right. I know it is not her, but the resemblance stops me in the doorway. I watch her trace a finger along the wooden pew before she turns and leaves.



Interior of St Martin's Church

The church suddenly feels too large and I escape outside to the warm evening air before dinner. Slovenian goulash arrives with less paprika and fewer vegetables than the Hungarian version, focusing instead on slow-cooked meat and rich gravy. Dessert is *grmada*, a traditional pudding made from leftover cake, rum-soaked sponge, walnuts, raisins, chocolate sauce and whipped cream.

I eat slowly. The physical routine of the meal brings me back to the present. I lift the fork, taste, chew and swallow. It is ordinary, but that is precisely what I need.

A final morning run begins at 7 am with rain hitting the lake in hard sheets. The postcard view has disappeared. Rain spreads across the surface, swans move close to the shore and the mountains fade behind curtains of mist. I arrive back soaked to the core with just enough time to change and dry my shoes before heading to the airport. At the departure gate, I eat a warm cheese borek and drink one final Balkan coffee while looking out of the window. The coffee is dark and thick.

My flight leaves on time and Slovenia vanishes under grey skies and low mist. The runway disappears behind rain as the aircraft climbs away.